powerful and became known as the ‘ataka khail’ – clan of the ataka

Jiji Anaka: Wife of Shamsuddin and one of Akbar’s most beloved foster mothers

Aziz Koka:[4] Son of Shamsuddin and Jiji. Akbar’s milk brother, best friend and most outspoken critic

Zain Khan Koka: Another of Akbar’s milk brothers. Best known for leading imperial troops against the Afghans of Swat and Bajaur and losing control of the campaign in which Birbar perished

Shihabuddin Ahmad Khan: Maham Anaka’s friend, relative and second-in-command. Served in Akbar’s court for decades after Maham Anaka’s death

Abul Ma’ali: A great favourite of Humayun’s; of handsome appearance and villainous nature. Plotted against Akbar and his family, briefly held the throne of Kabul

Bairam Khan: Became Akbar’s regent when Humayun died. Without him, Akbar might not have had an empire in Hindustan. Generous, ambitious and sometimes vengeful, was ousted in a coup led – most likely – by Maham Anaka

Abdur Rahim: Bairam Khan’s son. Orphaned at age four when Bairam Khan was murdered, brought up by Akbar in whose court he rose to Bairam Khan’s rank of khan-khanan – khan of khans

Husain Quli Khan: Bairam Khan’s nephew. Once disparaged by Akbar for not having fought so much as a chicken, his father was executed for supporting Bairam Khan’s rebellion. Rose to high rank as governor of both Punjab and the east, yet never seems to have gained Akbar’s affection, and was mistrusted by some of Akbar’s Sunni warlords because he was Shia

Tardi Beg: A tight-fisted but ultimately loyal warlord who served Humayun and – very briefly – Akbar. Was executed at Bairam Khan’s command

Munim Khan: Akbar’s ataliq – guardian – when Akbar was a prince. Allied with Maham Anaka against Bairam Khan. Led Akbar’s conquests into Bihar and Bengal, battling on Akbar’s behalf into his eighties

Jouher ‘Aftabchi’: Humayun’s ewer-bearer, served Akbar for decades and wrote an account of Humayun’s reign, including his exile from and return to Hindustan, the *Tezkereh al Vakiat*